

Lecture 6 Global Migration: Mobility and Security - Highlights

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International Relations



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Key Debates and Readings

Questions to be considered:

What drives international migration nowadays? Who counts as a migrant?

What dilemmas are liberal states facing when it comes to migration?

Why was the global refugee regime set up and what are its deficiencies?

Required readings:

1. Huysmans, J. “The European Union and the Securitization of Migration”, *Journal of Common Market Studies* 38, no. 5 (2000): 751-777.
2. Hollifield, J. F. (2004). The Emerging Migration State. *The International Migration Review*, 38(3), 885–912. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1747-7379.2004.tb00223.x>

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Migration**



**The Liberal State and
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Diplomacy**



Next week



The salience of migration policies



Recommended Readings

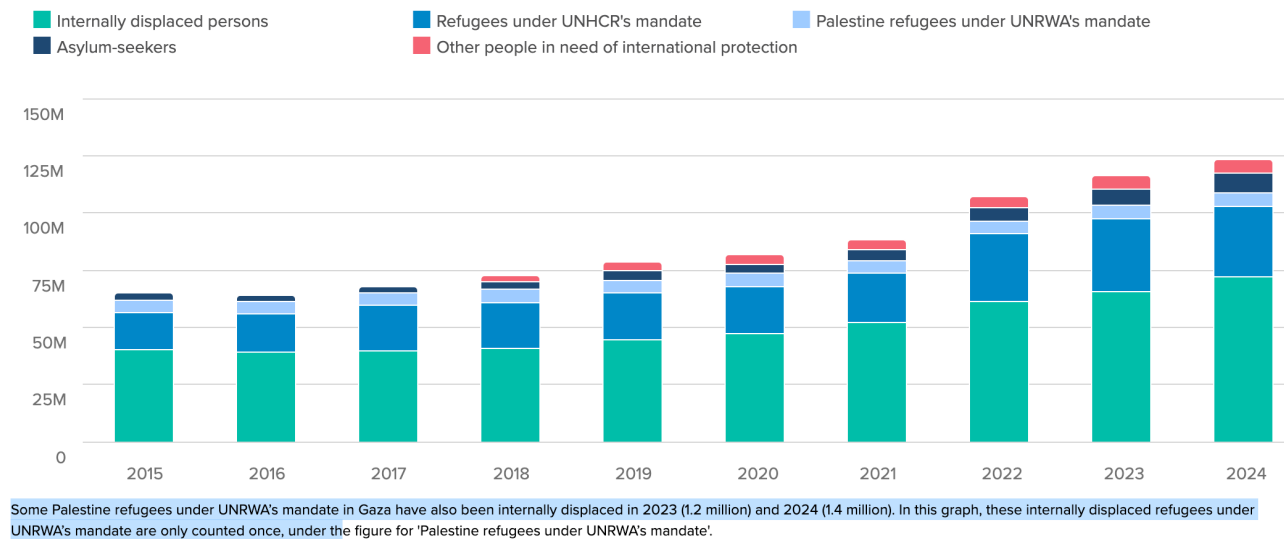
The Drivers of Migration



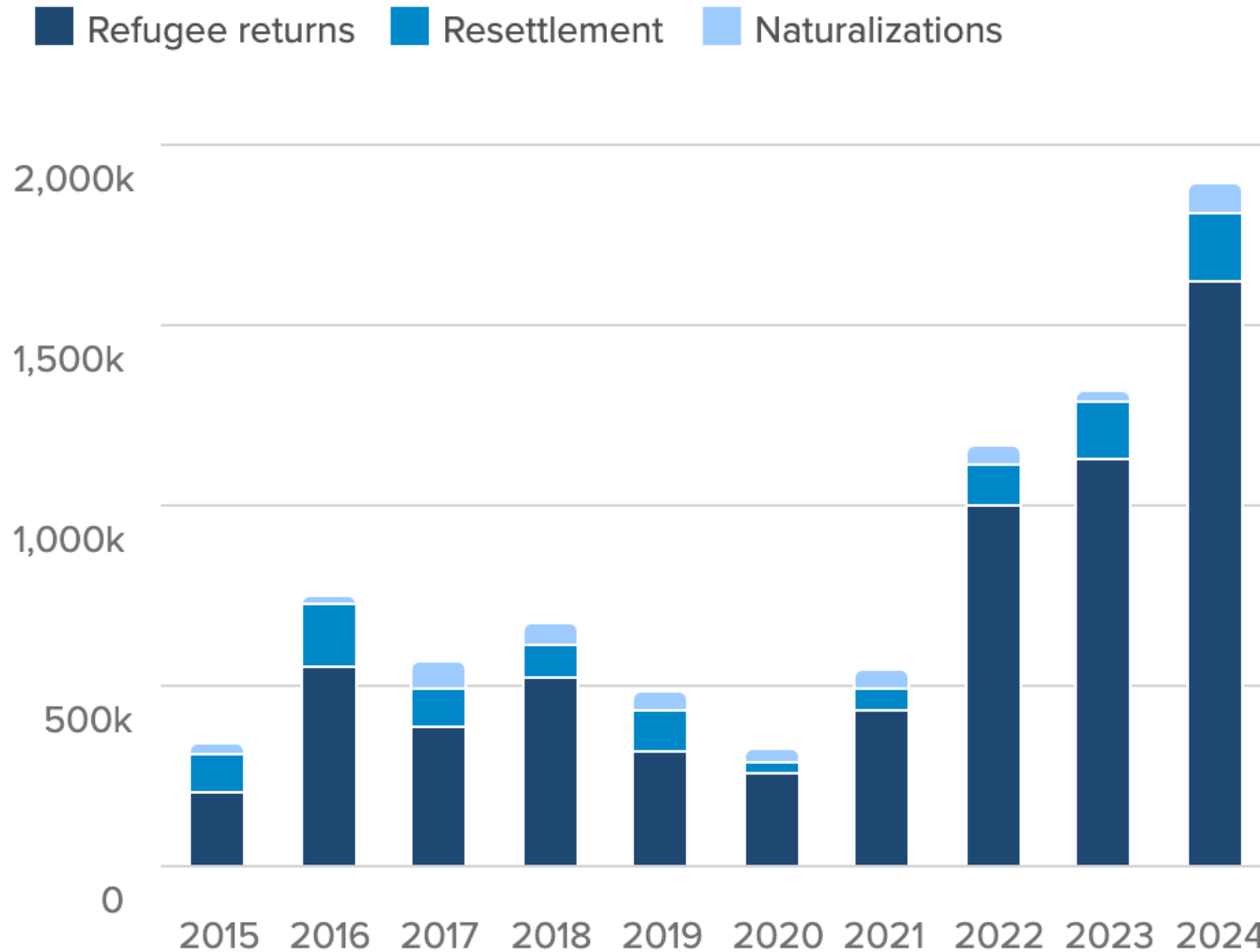
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People forcibly displaced worldwide- UNHCR Data

2015-2024



Refugee returns, resettlement and naturalization | 2015 - 2024





42.7 m

There were 42.7 million refugees globally at the end of 2024.



-1%

This is a 1 per cent decrease compared to the end of 2023.



73.5m

There were 73.5 million internally displaced people at the end of 2024.



+9%

This is a 9 per cent increase compared to the end of 2023.

4.8 MILLION

people sought international protection in 2024 (–13 per cent).

- 3.1 million new individual asylum applications were reported as registered.
- 835,600 people were recognized as refugees on a group basis (–6 per cent).
- 954,600 people received temporary protection (–13 per cent).

775,900

people were granted refugee status through individual status determination procedures (–6 per cent).

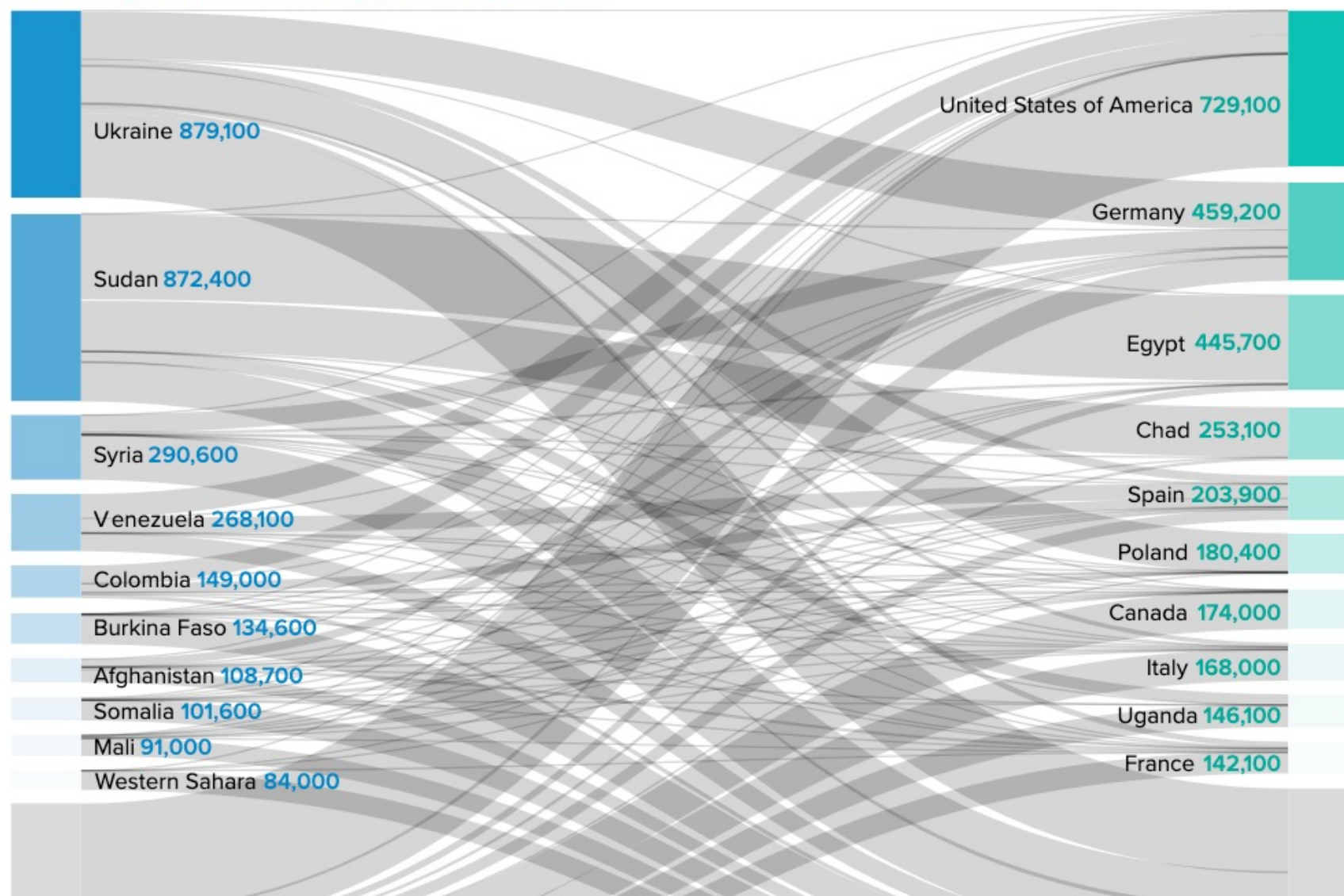
8.4 MILLION

asylum-seekers were pending a decision on their claims at end-2024.

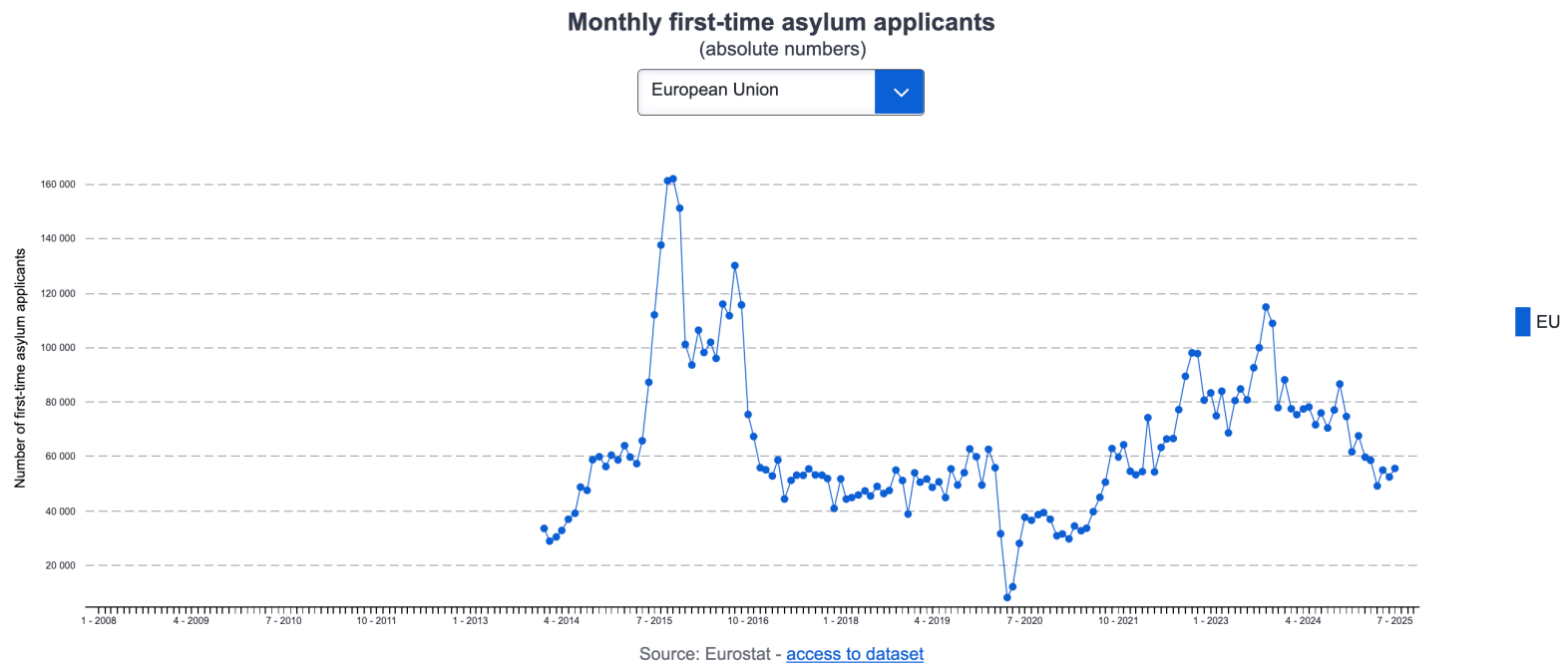
55%

was the total protection rate in individual procedures in 2024.¹⁶⁶

Figure 18 | **Key flows of people registering new individual asylum applications, recognised on a group basis or granted temporary protection | 2024**

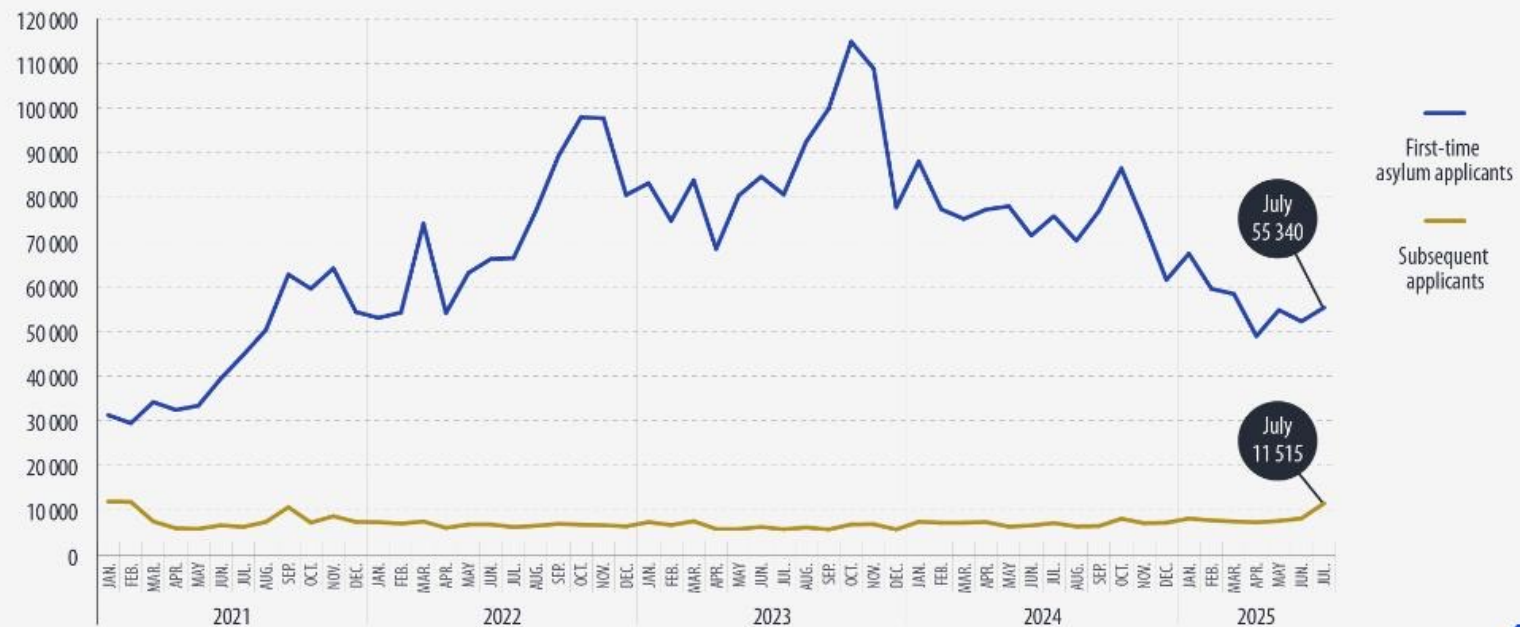


EU First Time Asylum applicants



First-time and subsequent asylum applicants in the EU, January 2021 - July 2025

(number of applicants)



Cyprus: due to temporary derogations, data on subsequent applicants are not available until December 2023, therefore Cyprus is not included in the total calculated until December 2023.
Spain: provisional data used since March 2025.
Czechia: July 2025 data not available, June 2025 data used to calculate EU totals.

eurostat 

Debunking some myths

- Migration usually is not for everyone: the 'poors remained trapped at home' (Parkes)
- Most migration is intra-regional
- South-North migration flows are declining and South-South migration is rising
- The 'age of migration' (Castles and al.) is likely to remain the 'new normal'



Definitions

➤ **Refugee (art. 1 Geneva Convention) is a person who**

‘owing to a well-founded fear of being persecuted for reasons of race, religion, nationality, membership of a particular social group or political opinion, is outside the country of his/ her nationality and is unable, or owing to such fear, is unwilling to avail him/herself of the protection of that country’

➤ **Asylum-seeker:** An asylum-seeker is someone who is seeking international protection. Their request for refugee status, or complementary protection status, has yet to be processed, or they may not yet have requested asylum but they intend to do so. (UNHCR)

➤ **Migrant :** ‘a person who moves away from his or her place of usual residence, whether within a country or across an international border, temporarily or permanently, and for a variety of reasons.’ ([IOM](#))

➤ **Internally Displaced Person IDP:** According to the United Nations Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement, Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs) are:

"[...] persons or groups of persons who have been forced or obliged to flee or to leave their homes or places of habitual residence, in particular as a result of or in order to avoid the effects of armed conflict, situations of generalized violence, violations of human rights or natural or human-made disasters, and who have not crossed an internationally recognized state border." ([UNHCR](#))

The Liberal State and Migration in International Relations



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The Liberal State, identity and citizenship

- For a very long time, migration policies were tackled from the perspective of **race**. Immigration policies helped to build the nation-state especially in settler states who wanted to populate their lands :
- **1901 Commonwealth Immigration Restriction Act**- known as the White Australia policy
- **1924 Reed-Johnson Immigration Act** excluded Asian immigrants in the US
- In Europe in post world war it was linked to the **colonial policy**. Colonial workers could settle in Europe, they were recruited. Quickly they had to stop and in the seventies most of European countries restricted labor migration.



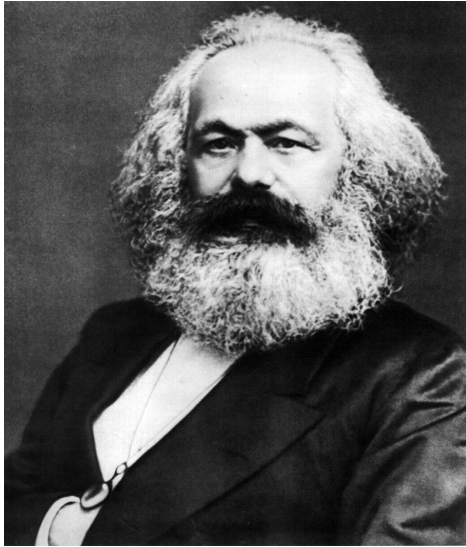
The ‘Liberal Paradox’ of the migration state (Hollifield, 1992)

- Paradox of Liberal states: since the 1970s states do not solicitate legal migration anymore (or less) like before with quotas or guestworkers programme; politicians short-termism and reelection
- Migration is now accepted for humanitarian reasons, the recognition of rights of migrants and refugees and family reunification ‘or because of the states’ sheer incapacity to keep migrants out, as in illegal immigration’
- **‘Why do liberal states accept unwanted immigration?’ (Joppke, 1998: 266)**

Regulating migration

- Migration is a transnational challenge for states and their borders, challenges governance at global, regional, national and local levels. New dimension is really the global level and regional consultation, new international organizations after IIWW (UNHCR, IOM, ILO)
- Before 1914 surprisingly migration was not seen as a challenge **for state's sovereignty**-> this changes after First World War (Castles, 2014: 5) => part of international diplomacy
- Important to understand **the type of policy instruments** (Wolff and Trauner, 2014) – policy instruments are not neutral:
 - readmission agreements
 - visa
 - work permits
 - residence permits
 - regularization, employers or carrier sanctions
 - points programs: high-skilled migration, Blue Card, Green Card
- **General trend: restrictive** immigration policies, attraction of high-skilled migrants, criminalization of migrants/ helpers, rise of human smuggling/ trafficking (in spite of more security)

Political Theory and Migration



Why is migration so prominent on policy agendas?

- Different theoretical explanations to the politicization/ political salience of migration:
 - **Securitization of migration**-> is Migration a security issue? (Bigo, Waever)
 - **Street-level bureaucrats** and role of Ministries of interior in leading agendas or border guards (Guiraudon, Lavenex)
 - **Identity and Failure of multi-cultural policies**-> are migrants challenging societies' identities? (Joppke)
 - **Ontological insecurity** and fear of the 'Other', 'Islam' and 'Migrants'=> Anxiety in societies (Kinnvall)
 - **Globalization**: acceleration of mobility and countries of emigration have become countries of 'transit' and destination (i.e. Morocco) plus neo-liberal reforms and need of cheap labour
 - **Euro-centric/ Western-centric approach to migration** which ignores the local circumstances of migration. In fact lots of migration is intra-regional. Need to de-centre our approaches to migration (i.e. N. El Qadim)

Securitization theory- The Copenhagen school

Copenhagen school (Buzan, Wæver) where securitization becomes a “speech-act”:

“Securitization is the move that takes politics beyond the established rules of the game and frames the issue either as a special sort of politics or as above politics” (Buzan et al. 1998: 23-26).

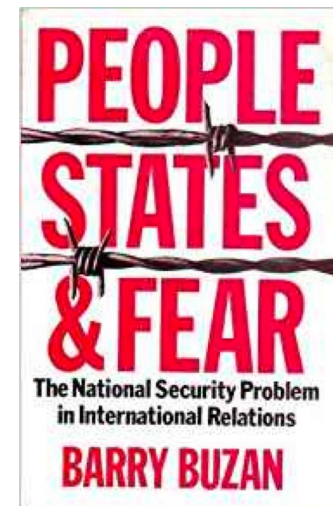
✓Conflict and Peace Research Institute of Copenhagen

✓Security is survival (Buzan et al. 1998: 21)

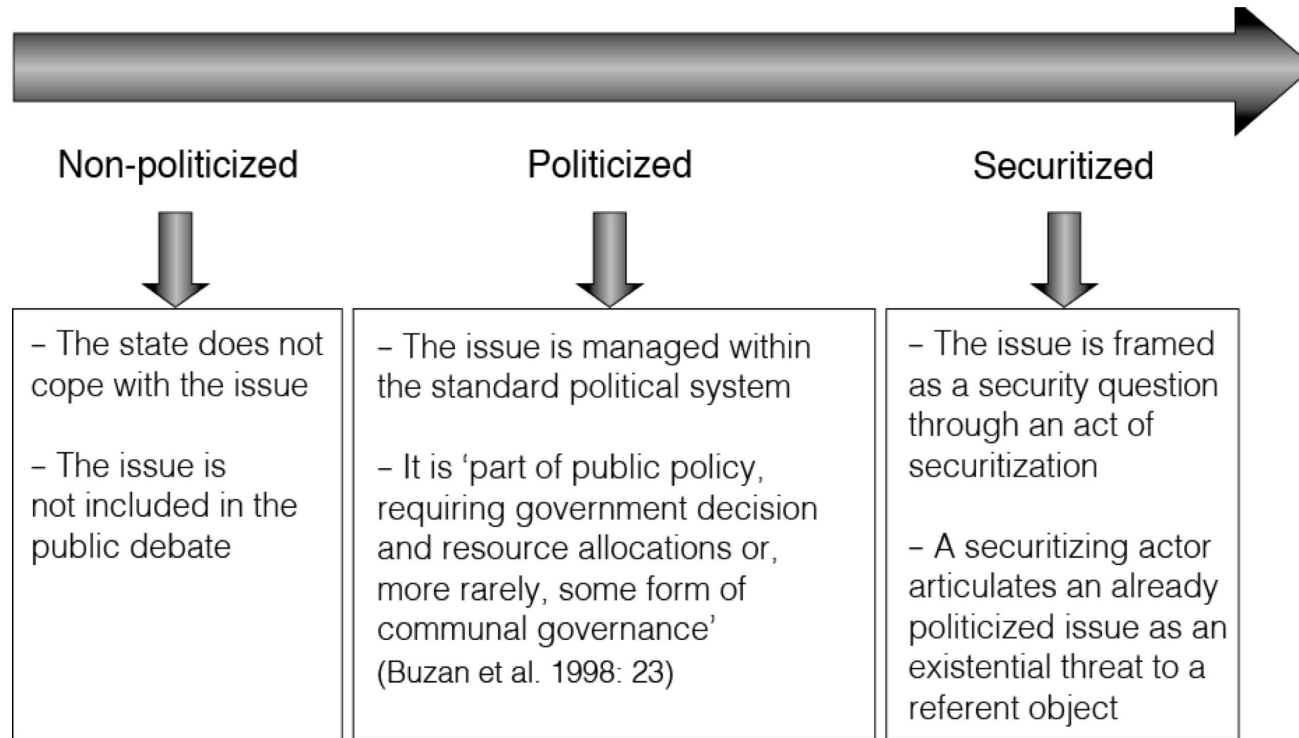
✓Security is speech act: ‘ ‘It is by labelling something a security issue that it becomes one’ (Wæver 2004: 13).
=>extraordinary measures, removed from normal politics and becomes emergency politics, circumventing democratic rules.

✓Next to military security they add 4 categories to security:

- Political
- Economic
- Societal and
- Environmental



Securitization theory- The Copenhagen school



Source: Emmers (2011: 138)

Critical theory- The Paris School

Control practices are 'routinely embedded in a practical sense that informs what controlling borders does and means

⇒ Use of '**sociological intervention method**' 'that enables the actors themselves to access certain forms of consciousness

⇒ Look at '**everyday practices that** enact a governmentality of fear and unease' (Bigo, 2014: 211)

✓ **Militarization of border controls is in fact limited** (Bigo) in the central justification of border personnel (EU NavforMed- Brief)

✓ Even if of military background, **European border guards socialized to the idea of Europeanised border control** and 'see themselves as managers of flows' and as 'the ultimate judges of the true behavior of an individual' (Bigo, 2014: 215)

✓ **Digitalisation of borders**, preventive work, importance of biometrics (i.e. Eurodac database). They do not see borders as barriers but 'as a series of disconnected geographical points, linked through speed of information and data sharing' (Bigo, 2014:217)

The Global Refugee Regime and Migration Diplomacy



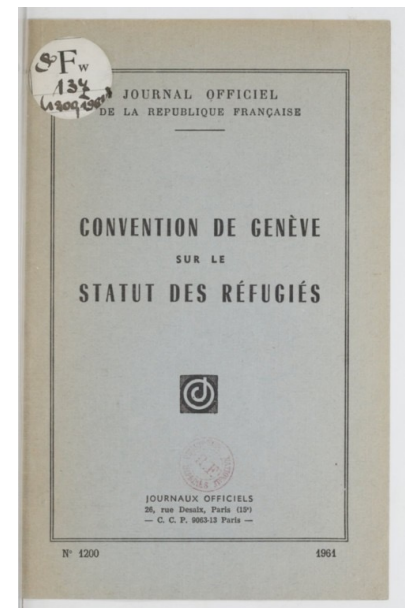
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Global Refugee Regime

- a set of norms and institutions relating to protection and solutions for Refugees or also defined by Betts (2015) as the architecture of reciprocal support that confers a set of global public goods in the field of asylum

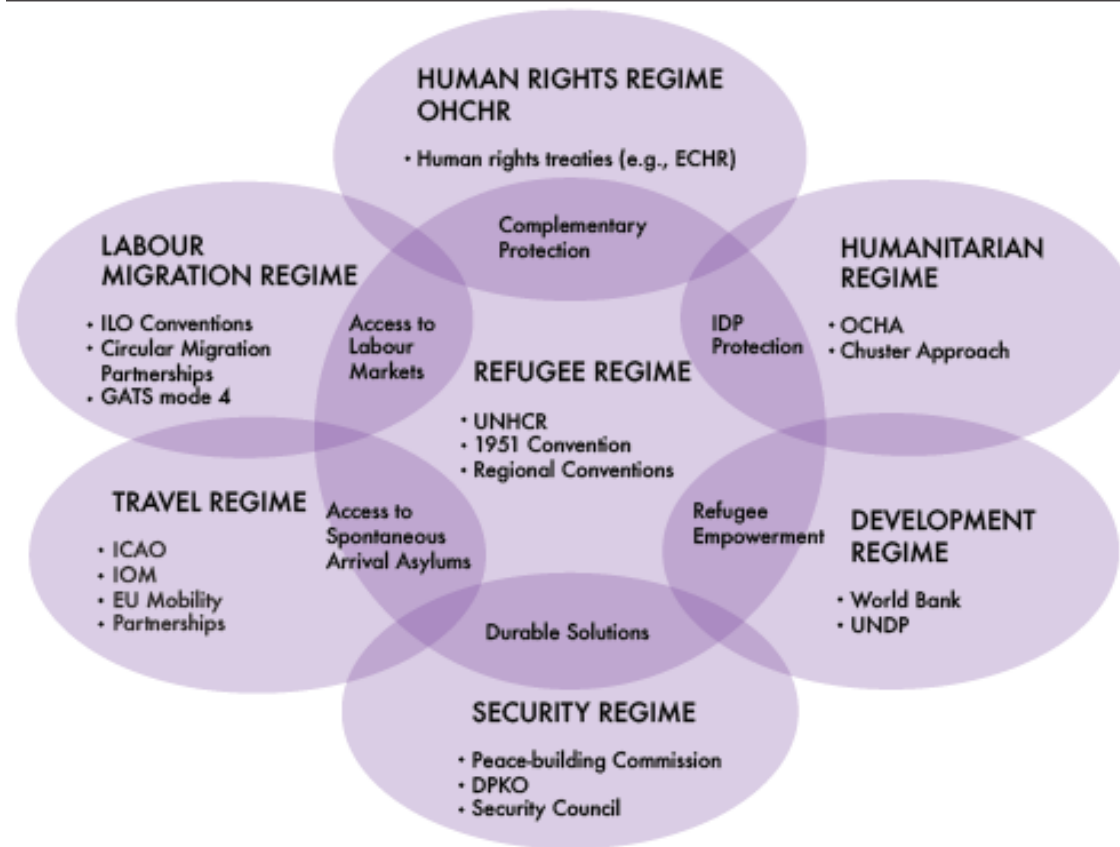


Supported by UNHCR,
the UN Refugee Agency



Source gallica.bnf.fr / Bibliothèque nationale de France

Betts and Milner 2019



Migration Diplomacy

Diplomatic Practices:

- Coercive or Cooperative Practices
- Blackmailing or backscratching practices
- Externalization as only one type of migration diplomacy practice

Material Gains:

- economic gain: trade agreement/ grant (i.e. tomato)
- institutional benefit: membership in an organization i.e. Turkey
- aid: military/ humanitarian

But not just a bargain, also about Symbolic gain:

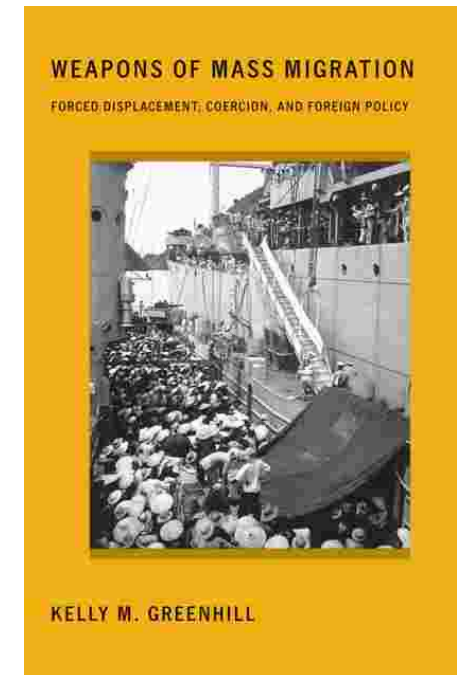
soft power, cultural/symbolic

Ideology with refugees during Cold war (which regime was fled)

Authoritarian regime to improve their external image. I.e. Morocco Western Africa

Status, Reputation, Moral Standing Gains-> Tolay

=> instead of bargains think about interactions (Tolay)



Tolay, J. (2022). Interrogating and Broadening the Emerging Narrative on Migration Diplomacy: A Critical Assessment.

EU Migration Diplomacy: ineffective?

- **EU-Tunisia deal 16 July 2023 MoU 5 pillars**

- Complements the EU-Tunisia Association Agreement
- Priority on irregular migration, avoiding loss of human life, developing legal pathways
- Combating smuggling and human trafficking

- **Budget**

- €105 million to support Tunisian coastguards & border control
- €900 million in macroeconomic support and €150 million in direct budgetary support.



EU Migration Diplomacy

- Asylum and Migration perceived increasingly as a geopolitical risk
- Blackmailing the EU
- Strategy to return migrants back home

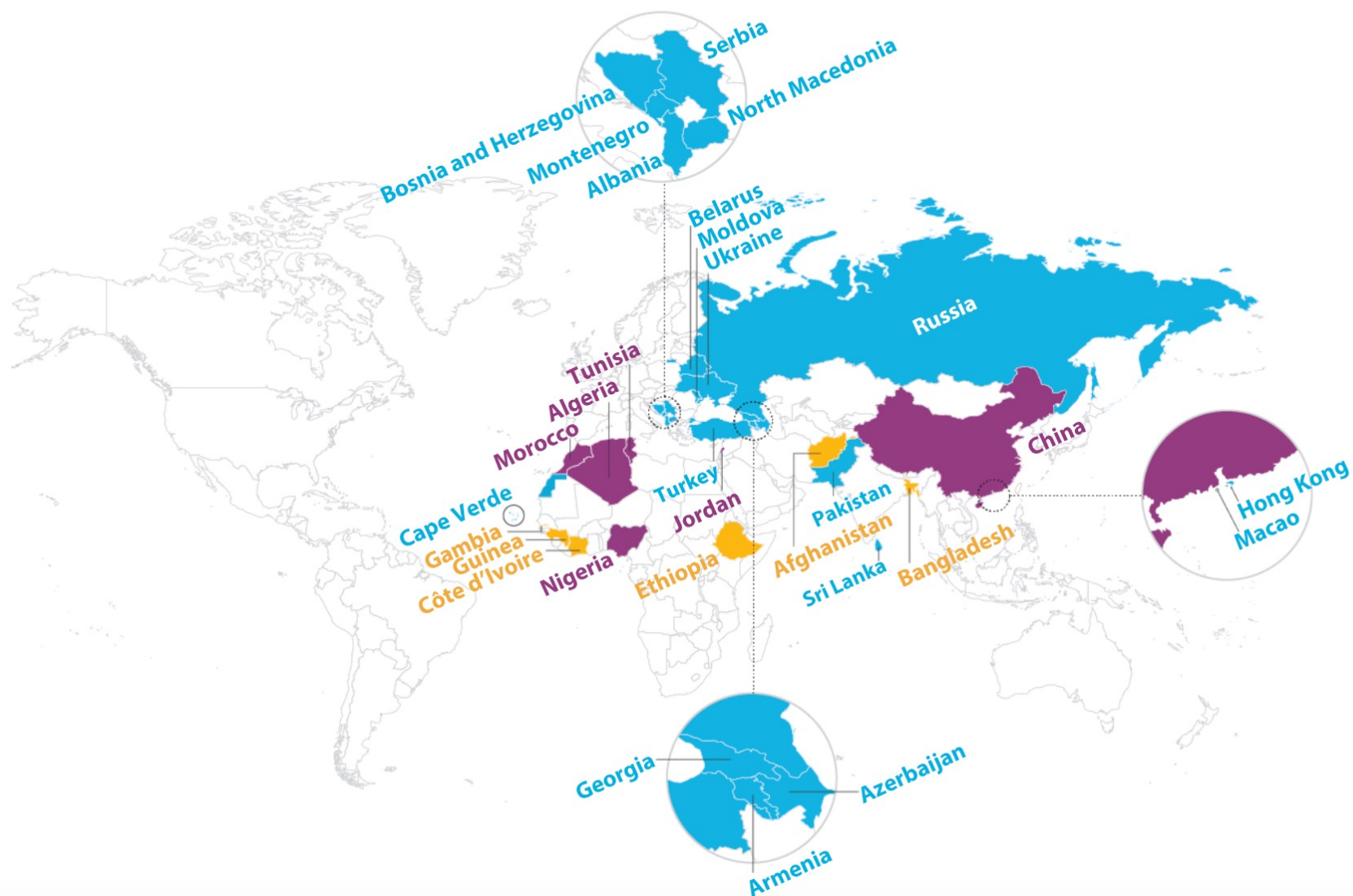


Figure 3 – Return decisions and effective returns (in thousands)



Data sources: [Eurostat](https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat).

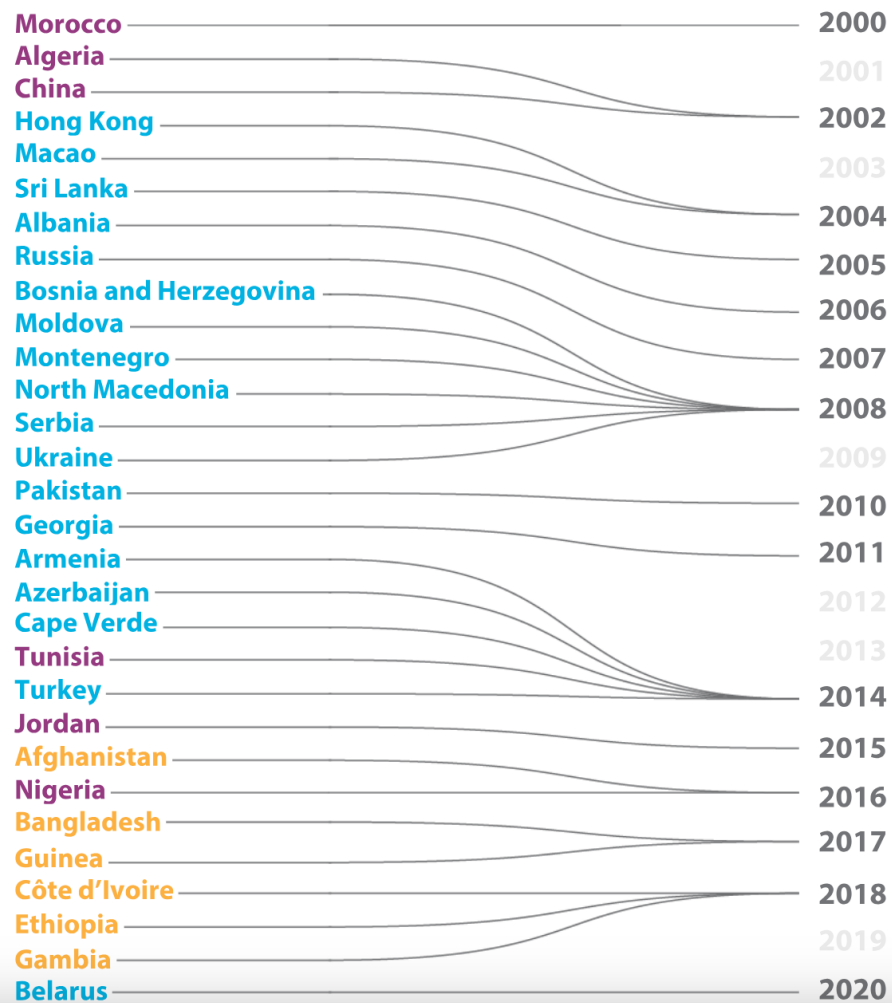
Map of EURAs and non-binding readmission arrangements



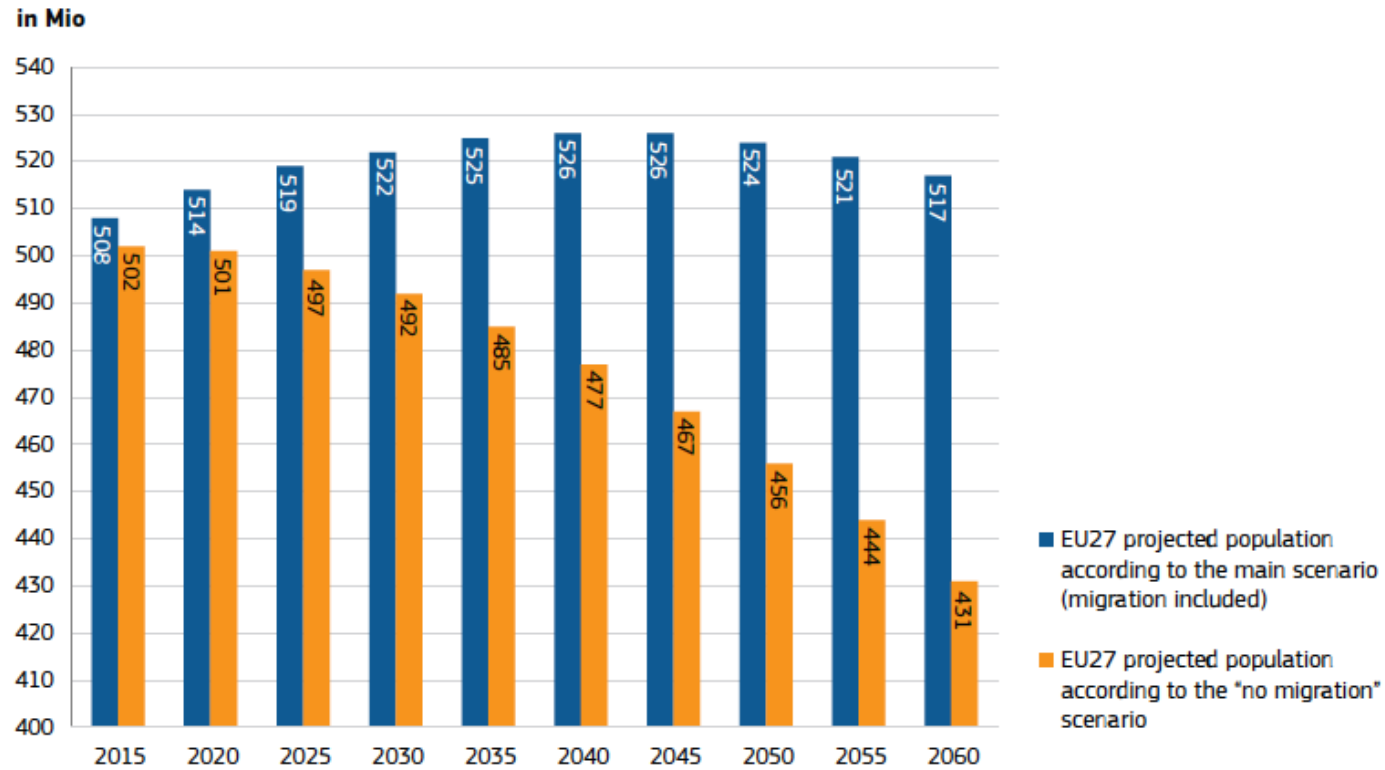
● Readmission agreement; entry into force

● Mandate to negotiate; date

● Readmission arrangements; entry into force



Demographic Challenges: Europe Needs Migration



Source: DG Home

Extra references

Betts, A. (2015). The normative terrain of the global refugee regime. *Ethics & International Affairs*, 29(4), 363-375.

Betts, A., & Milner, J. (2019). Governance of the Global Refugee Regime.

<https://www.cigionline.org/sites/default/files/documents/WRC%20Research%20Paper%20No.13.pdf>

Wolff, S. (2024). The New Pact on Migration: Embedded Illiberalism?. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 62, 113-123.

30 March: War, Peace and International Security (Wolff)

Questions to be considered:

Is peace the continuation of war by other means?

Is war always between sovereign citizens?

How are international and domestic dimensions of war and peace intertwined?

Required readings:

1. Heywood, A., & Whitham, B. (2023). Global politics (3rd ed., Chapter 11: War and Peace). London: Red Globe Press.

1. Barkawi (2016). Decolonising war. European Journal of International security, 1(2), 199-214

Thank you!



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